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Question

The ancient Greek concept of “mimesis,” a term used in the works of Plato, Aristotle, and other Greek philosophers in discussions of representational art—visual, performance, or literary art that aims to depict the real world—is a foundational concept of the Western philosophy of aesthetics. Mimesis is typically translated as “imitation” in modern editions of ancient Greek texts, but scholar Stephen Halliwell warns that this is overly reductive: “imitation” implies that art merely copies—and is thus by definition entirely derivative of—a reality that exists outside and prior to the work of art, and translating “mimesis” thusly obscures the multifaceted ways in which the ancient Greeks understood the relationship between art and reality.

Which statement, if true, would most directly support the claim by Halliwell presented in the text?

Answer

- A. One of the earliest appearances of mimesis’s root word, *mimos*, can be found in an ancient Greek tragedy in reference to dramatic impersonation, and the *mim*- root came to be generally associated with the musical and poetic arts by the fifth century BCE.
- B. Both Plato’s and Aristotle’s theorizations of mimesis examine the psychological effects that works of art induce in the viewer or listener.
- C. Although several of Plato’s earliest philosophical works discuss aesthetic ideas, the term “mimesis” doesn’t appear in Plato’s discussions of art until *Cratylus*, a relatively late work.
- D. Although Plato’s writings typically characterize representational art as an inferior reflection of the physical world, Aristotle suggests that mimesis can refer to art’s capacity to envision hypothetical conditions that could, but don’t yet, exist.